

Rayner's Natural Inclusion and the Repo's Themes

Question: How do the themes in *Receptive Simplicity in the Heart of Complexity.pdf* align with the other themes that we have been exploring?

Receptive Simplicity in the Heart of Complexity is Alan Rayner's own material — the PDF's metadata names him as author — and it's the same Alan Rayner cited by name in Chapter 2 of *What Matters?* (Flach & Voorhorst) as the source of the "Inclusional" framework the book uses to get past EITHER/OR argument toward BOTH/AND. So this isn't a new thread — it's the primary source for a citation already sitting in this repo's material. It's a 2022 slide deck (LibreOffice Impress) mixing terse concept-slides, Rayner's own paintings, and free verse under the concept "Natural Inclusion."

Where It Lines Up Closely

- **Anti-dualism as a relational third option.** Rayner's "Objective Perception" (isolates observer from observed) vs. "Subjective Perception" (collapses observer into observed) vs. "Comprehensive Perception" (combines focus with circumspection) is structurally identical to *What Matters?*'s Discoverer/Inventor/Pluralistic-Epistemology move in Chapter 2 — and to Pirsig's claim that Quality precedes the subject/object split rather than living in either half.
- **Boundaries as dynamic, not static.** "Natural bodily boundaries are intrinsically dynamic... they disappear if [energy flow] ceases" and "boundaries are responsive energetic distinctions, not isolators" is the same anti-Cartesian move Gibson makes with affordances (neither purely in the organism nor purely in the environment) and that the Affording-Specifying-Satisfying triad makes throughout *What Matters?* and Chapter 33 of *Cognitive Systems Engineering* — meaning is relational, not a property parked on one side of a boundary.
- **Dynamic self-maintenance via continuous flow.** Rayner's "continuous intangible presence that... invites energy flow both inwardly and outwardly" sustaining material bodies is a poetic cousin of Friston's Free Energy Principle discussed in `Free Energy.md`: a Markov blanket is likewise a dynamic, not static, boundary that only persists by continuously exchanging with its surround.
- **Scale invariance.** "From sub-atomic to galactic" is the same fractal, turtles-all-the-way-down move *What Matters?* makes running the triadic semiotic dynamic from individual cognition up through organizations (Chapter 14) — one relational pattern, repeated at every scale.
- **BOTH-AND over EITHER-OR.** Rayner's "You Can't Have Half a Hole" indictment of Occam's razor and the Law of the Excluded Middle is a more polemical version of the same target Peircean abduction, Rasmussen's multi-level pluralism, and Pirsig's anti-analytic stance all take: classical bivalent logic as the wrong benchmark for a living, relational reality.

Where It Genuinely Departs

- **Register.** Everything else in this thread — Peirce, James, Gibson, Rasmussen, Friston, even Pirsig — stays tethered to a discipline with methods (semiotics, psychology, control engineering, variational inference). Rayner's is devotional and poetic ("the love in our life," "soul and spirit," "natural communion"), closer to nature-mysticism than to philosophy of science.

- **No cash value.** Flach ties the metaphysics back to something actionable — interface design, training design, control stability. Friston ties his to a mathematical objective function. Rayner's slides don't point anywhere except back at themselves; there's no design or prediction that falls out of "natural inclusion" the way Ecological Interface Design falls out of the triadic semiotic.
- **Totalizing tone.** Calling Occam's razor and the Excluded Middle "the murder weapon destroying life on Earth" is considerably more absolute than Flach and Voorhorst, who explicitly preserve a role for mathematics and analytic thinking (*What Matters?* Chapters 15–16) even while critiquing its overreach.

Net Assessment

Same structural move as the whole thoughtline — a relational ontology prior to subject/object, pursued by the same author *What Matters?* cites — but carried out as poetry and spiritual conviction rather than as a scientific or design-oriented argument.